



disallowed one, were built up through the flanks.

Against Japan in the second game, nine out of 11 goals were conceded in the same fashion. Full-backs such as Sanju Yadav and Nirmala Devi Phanjoubam will have to reflect on their performances, but so too must Valverde, who failed to address the same issues across successive matches.

Sweetie and goalkeeper Panthoi Chanu Elangbam, who thwarted numerous scoring chances, fought valiantly, but football is ultimately a collective effort.

In attack, opportunities were scarce. Pyari Xaxa was largely isolated, while Lynda Kom Serto and Sanfida Nongrum got limited game time. Sangita Basfore, a standout performer in the qualifiers, struggled, aside from a long-range attempt against Vietnam in the opening game.

Losing possession cheaply in its own half, a lack of communication, and subdued intent only made

things worse for the team.

Amid the disappointment, however, there were a few positives.

Of India's two goals in the tournament, one of them was a stunning free-kick by Manisha Kalyan against Chinese Taipei.

Manisha, who stood out as India's most influential player in this tournament, remains the only regular member currently playing in a foreign league — Peruvian top-flight side Alianza Lima — though several others have gained experience abroad in the past.

Soumya Guguloth finished as runner-up with Dinamo Zagreb in Croatia in 2022–23, Grace Dangmei won the Uzbekistan Women's League with Sevinch Karshi in 2022, and Panthoi had a stint at Australian second-division side Metro United. Aveka Singh still plays for Danish second-division side Næstved HG.

More Indian players have moved to foreign shores — Kajol D'Souza (Al-Amal, UAE), Rivka Ramji (Lion City Sailors, Singapore), and Harshika Jain

Spark among ruins: Manisha Kalyan's blazing free-kick against Chinese Taipei was a rare bright spot for India in the tournament. GETTY IMAGES (ACS Athletic Olimpia Gherla, Romania).

There is potential for the winds to change in India, and Valverde's appointment, given her experience, was a step in the right direction.

The Costa Rican was instrumental in professionalising the women's game in her country and has the credentials to bring a similar transformation to India. However, she will require something the AIFF has struggled to provide: time. So, it remains to be seen whether Valverde will continue in her role.

India's women's team, currently ranked 67th in the world — significantly ahead of the men's 141st — remains the country's best shot at a World Cup appearance. But for that ambition to be realised, the system designed to support it must stop being its greatest impediment.